

STUDY NOTES · UPSSSC PET 2026

General English — Vocabulary

UPSSSC PET 2026 Detailed Notes · Synonyms, Antonyms, Idioms & OWS

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General English

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General English — Vocabulary

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Scope: Synonyms • Antonyms • One Word Substitution • Commonly Used Words • Idioms/Phrases
• Spelling

Method: Meaning → Usage → Context → Practice

∴ note **Hindi Help:** English is the primary language. Hindi is used only for difficult meanings, distinctions, or memory support. ∴

1. What is Vocabulary?

Vocabulary is the collection of words a learner understands and uses. In competitive exams, vocabulary questions test **meaning, word relationships, correct usage, spelling, and context.**

For PET, a useful vocabulary record contains:

1. Word
2. Meaning
3. Part of speech
4. Synonym
5. Antonym, where useful
6. Example sentence
7. Confusing word, where applicable
8. Correct spelling

💡 Exam Tip

Do not memorise a word only as a Hindi translation. Learn it with a short English sentence so you can recognise it in a question or passage.

2. Synonyms

A **synonym** is a word with the same or a very similar meaning in a particular context. Exact interchangeability is not guaranteed in every sentence.



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2.1 High-Frequency Synonyms — A-C

Word	Synonym	Short Meaning
Abandon	Leave	give up/leave
Abolish	End	officially end
Abrupt	Sudden	unexpected
Accurate	Exact	correct
Adequate	Sufficient	enough
Adversity	Hardship	difficult condition
Alleviate	Relieve	make less severe
Ambiguous	Unclear	more than one possible meaning
Ancient	Old	belonging to the distant past
Apparent	Obvious	easy to notice
Arrogant	Haughty	overly proud
Authentic	Genuine	real
Benevolent	Kind	well-meaning
Brief	Short	not long
Brutal	Cruel	harsh/violent
Cautious	Careful	avoiding risk
Cease	Stop	come to an end
Commence	Begin	start
Compel	Force	make someone do something
Conceal	Hide	keep from view
Confess	Admit	acknowledge wrongdoing/truth
Conspicuous	Noticeable	easy to see

Word	Synonym	Short Meaning
Courageous	Brave	showing courage

2.2 High-Frequency Synonyms — D-H

Word	Synonym	Short Meaning
Diligent	Hardworking	careful and industrious
Diminish	Reduce	become/make smaller
Diverse	Varied	different
Eager	Keen	enthusiastic
Eliminate	Remove	get rid of
Essential	Necessary	absolutely needed
Evident	Clear	easy to see/understand
Fragile	Delicate	easily broken
Frequent	Often	occurring repeatedly
Genuine	Authentic	real
Generous	Liberal	willing to give
Hostile	Unfriendly	antagonistic
Humble	Modest	not boastful

2.3 High-Frequency Synonyms — I-P

Word	Synonym	Short Meaning
Inevitable	Unavoidable	certain to happen
Infer	Deduce	conclude from evidence
Intelligent	Clever	mentally capable
Lament	Mourn	express sorrow
Mandatory	Compulsory	required
Meticulous	Careful	very precise/careful
Obsolete	Outdated	no longer in use
Obvious	Evident	easy to understand
Persuade	Convince	cause someone to agree
Precise	Exact	accurate
Prohibit	Forbid	officially prevent

2.4 High-Frequency Synonyms — R-Z

Word	Synonym	Short Meaning
Rapid	Swift	very fast
Rare	Uncommon	not common
Reluctant	Unwilling	not ready/willing
Reliable	Dependable	can be trusted
Reveal	Disclose	make known
Significant	Important	meaningful
Sufficient	Enough	adequate
Temporary	Short-term	not permanent
Vacant	Empty	unoccupied
Vital	Essential	extremely important
Weary	Tired	exhausted

⚠ Warning

Synonyms are often **context-dependent**. Two words may be similar in one sentence but not interchangeable in every situation.

3. Antonyms

An **antonym** expresses an opposite or contrasting meaning.

3.1 High-Frequency Antonym Pairs

Word	Antonym
Abundant	Scarce
Accept	Reject
Ancient	Modern
Artificial	Natural
Arrival	Departure
Attractive	Repulsive
Bold	Timid
Broad	Narrow
Cautious	Careless
Complex	Simple
Create	Destroy
Expand	Contract
External	Internal
Failure	Success
Generous	Stingy
Guilty	Innocent
Hope	Despair
Humble	Arrogant
Increase	Decrease
Maximum	Minimum
Permanent	Temporary
Public	Private

Word	Antonym
Rare	Common
Victory	Defeat
Visible	Invisible



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3.2 More Important Pairs

Word	Antonym
Active	Passive
Advantage	Disadvantage
Capable	Incapable
Cheap	Expensive
Courage	Cowardice
Domestic	Foreign
Early	Late
Flexible	Rigid
Friend	Enemy
Include	Exclude
Liberty	Slavery
Major	Minor
Optimist	Pessimist
Partial	Complete
Polite	Rude
Prosperity	Poverty
Strength	Weakness
Transparent	Opaque

⚡ Trick

For an antonym, first identify the **exact meaning** of the given word. Then choose the option that directly reverses or contrasts that meaning.

4. One Word Substitution

One-word substitution replaces a phrase or description with one suitable English word.



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4.1 Persons

Description	One Word
One who cannot read or write	Illiterate
One who loves mankind	Philanthropist
One who hates mankind	Misanthrope
One who loves books	Bibliophile
One who knows many languages	Polyglot
One who speaks two languages	Bilingual
One who looks at the bright side	Optimist
One who expects the worst	Pessimist
One who cannot be corrected	Incorrigible
One who travels from place to place	Itinerant
One who eats too much	Glutton
One who talks too much	Garrulous
One who is new to an activity	Novice
One who knows everything	Omniscient
One who is all-powerful	Omnipotent
One who is present everywhere	Omnipresent
One who hates women	Misogynist
One who studies mankind	Anthropologist
One who studies plants	Botanist
One who studies animals	Zoologist
One who studies stars/space	Astronomer
One who writes poems	Poet

Description	One Word
One who writes plays	Dramatist
One who writes dictionaries	Lexicographer

4.2 Places and Institutions

Description	One Word
Place where books are kept	Library
Place where animals are kept	Zoo
Place where aircraft are kept	Hangar
Place where coins are made	Mint
Place where weapons are stored	Arsenal
Place where dead bodies are examined/kept	Morgue
Place where soldiers live	Barracks
Place where monks live	Monastery
Place where nuns live	Convent
Place where prisoners are kept	Prison
Place where experiments are conducted	Laboratory
Place where birds are kept	Aviary
Place where bees are kept	Apiary
Place where ships are repaired/kept	Dockyard

4.3 Concepts and Conditions

Description	One Word
That which cannot be avoided	Inevitable
That which cannot be seen	Invisible
That which cannot be heard	Inaudible
That which cannot be conquered	Invincible
That which cannot be cured	Incurable
That which cannot be believed	Incredible
That which cannot be read	Illegible
That which cannot be explained	Inexplicable
That which can be used only once	Disposable
A speech made without preparation	Extempore
Life history written by oneself	Autobiography
Life history written by another	Biography
Government by the people	Democracy
Government by one person	Autocracy
Government by a small group	Oligarchy

Remember

Autobiography = life story written by oneself.

Biography = life story written by another person.

5. Commonly Used Words

Word	Meaning	Example
Adequate	enough	The resources are adequate.
Cautious	careful	Be cautious while driving.
Concise	brief but complete	Give a concise answer.
Diligent	hardworking	She is a diligent student.
Elaborate	detailed	He gave an elaborate explanation.
Genuine	real	This is a genuine document.
Hostile	unfriendly	The crowd became hostile.
Inevitable	unavoidable	Change is inevitable.
Mandatory	required	Attendance is mandatory.
Obsolete	outdated	The machine is obsolete.
Precise	exact	Give a precise answer.
Reluctant	unwilling	He was reluctant to speak.
Significant	important	It was a significant decision.
Sufficient	enough	The evidence is sufficient.
Transparent	clear/open	The process should be transparent.
Vulnerable	easily harmed	Some groups are vulnerable.
Ambiguous	unclear	The statement is ambiguous.
Adverse	unfavourable/harmful	The medicine caused adverse effects.
Compulsory	mandatory	Attendance is compulsory.
Meticulous	very careful	She is meticulous in her work.

6. Idioms and Phrases

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose overall meaning cannot always be understood by translating each word literally.

6.1 Important Idioms — A-M

Idiom	Meaning	Example
A blessing in disguise	apparently bad but ultimately beneficial	The delay was a blessing in disguise.
A piece of cake	very easy	The task was a piece of cake.
At the eleventh hour	at the last moment	He applied at the eleventh hour.
Break the ice	start a friendly interaction	The teacher told a joke to break the ice.
Burn the midnight oil	work/study late at night	She burned the midnight oil before the exam.
Call it a day	stop work for the day	Let us call it a day.
Hit the nail on the head	say exactly the right thing	You hit the nail on the head.
In hot water	in trouble	He is in hot water.
Once in a blue moon	very rarely	He visits us once in a blue moon.
Spill the beans	reveal a secret	She spilled the beans.
Under the weather	feeling unwell	I am under the weather today.

6.2 Important Idioms — N-Z

Idiom	Meaning	Example
On cloud nine	extremely happy	She was on cloud nine.
See eye to eye	agree completely	We do not always see eye to eye.
Take to task	scold/criticise	The manager took him to task.
The last straw	final problem in a series	The delay was the last straw.
Through thick and thin	in good and bad times	They supported each other through thick and thin.
Turn a deaf ear	refuse to listen	He turned a deaf ear to the warning.
A storm in a teacup	fuss about a small matter	It was a storm in a teacup.
Cost an arm and a leg	be very expensive	The car cost an arm and a leg.
Keep an eye on	watch carefully	Keep an eye on the child.
Make both ends meet	manage financially	It is difficult to make both ends meet.
Put off	postpone	They put off the meeting.
Look down upon	regard as inferior	Never look down upon others.
In the long run	eventually/over time	It will help in the long run.
By leaps and bounds	very rapidly	The company is growing by leaps and bounds.

⚠ Warning

Do not translate idioms word-for-word. Learn **idiom** → **meaning** → **example** as one unit.

Hindi Help: Idiom का meaning अक्सर literal words से अलग होता है।

7. Spelling

Spelling questions may ask you to identify the correctly spelled word or the incorrect spelling.

7.1 High-Frequency Spellings

Correct	Common Wrong Form
Accommodation	Accomodation
Beginning	Begining
Beautiful	Beautifull
Calendar	Calender
Committee	Commitee
Definitely	Definately
Environment	Enviroment
Government	Goverment
Independent	Independant
Necessary	Necesary
Occurrence	Occurence
Privilege	Priviledge
Pronunciation	Pronounciation
Receive	Recieve
Separate	Seperate
Successful	Succesful
Tomorrow	Tommorow
Maintenance	Maintainance
Questionnaire	Questionaire
Embarrass	Embarass
Existence	Existance
Knowledge	Knowlege

Correct	Common Wrong Form
Liaison	Liason
Millennium	Millenium
Restaurant	Restuarant
Rhythm	Rythm

7.2 Spelling Clues

Pay special attention to:

- double consonants
- vowel order
- silent letters
- common suffixes
- repeated letters

⚡ Trick

When options look similar, compare them letter-by-letter. Do not rely only on how the word sounds.

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8. Homophones and Confusing Words

Word 1	Word 2	Difference
accept	except	receive/agree vs excluding
advice	advise	noun vs verb
affect	effect	usually verb vs usually noun
principal	principle	head/main vs rule/belief
stationery	stationary	writing materials vs not moving
complement	compliment	completes vs praise
loose	lose	not tight vs fail to keep
later	latter	afterwards vs second of two
beside	besides	next to vs in addition
personal	personnel	individual/private vs staff
adapt	adopt	adjust vs take up/accept
assure	ensure	tell confidently vs make certain
allusion	illusion	indirect reference vs false appearance
moral	morale	principle of right/wrong vs confidence/spirit
practice	practise	noun vs verb in British usage
conscience	conscious	moral sense vs aware
desert	dessert	dry region/abandon vs sweet course

Example

Advice / Advise

- He gave me useful **advice**. → noun
- I **advise** you to study. → verb

Principal / Principle

- The school **principal** addressed the students.
- Honesty is an important **principle**.

9. Word Formation

Prefixes and suffixes can help you infer meaning and grammatical category.

9.1 Common Prefixes

Prefix	General idea	Example
un-	not/reversal	unhappy
dis-	opposite/absence	dishonest
re-	again	rewrite
mis-	wrongly	misunderstand
pre-	before	preview
post-	after	postgraduate
anti-	against	antiwar
inter-	between	international
intra-	within	intrastate
sub-	under/below	submarine
super-	above/beyond	supernatural
trans-	across	transport

9.2 Common Suffixes

Suffix	Common role	Example
-ness	noun	kindness
-ment	noun	development
-tion/-sion	noun	education, decision
-ity	noun	ability
-er/-or	person/agent	teacher, actor
-ful	adjective	useful
-less	adjective	careless
-able/-ible	adjective	readable, visible
-ly	commonly adverb	quickly

Exam Tip

Prefixes and suffixes are clues, not guaranteed formulas. Confirm the meaning from context.

10. Vocabulary in Context

When an unfamiliar word appears in a sentence or passage, use context clues.

Definition Clue

The sentence directly explains the word.

Contrast Clue

Words such as **but**, **however**, **unlike**, **although** may signal contrast.

Example Clue

Examples around the word may reveal its meaning.

Restatement Clue

A later phrase may express the same idea in simpler language.

::: strategy **Context-solving method:**

1. Read the whole sentence.
2. Identify the likely part of speech.
3. Read before and after the word.
4. Look for definition, contrast, example, or restatement.
5. Substitute each option mentally.
6. Select the option that fits the complete context. :::

11. Vocabulary by Part of Speech

Learning related forms helps with sentence-based questions.

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
success	succeed	successful	successfully
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
decision	decide	decisive	decisively
difference	differ	different	differently
importance	—	important	importantly
care	care	careful/careless	carefully/carelessly
confidence	—	confident	confidently
patience	—	patient	patiently

::: note Not every word has a common form in all four columns. Learn natural usage rather than forcing a word into every category. :::

12. High-Frequency Vocabulary Bank

A-E

- Abandon — leave/give up
- Abolish — officially end
- Abundant — plentiful
- Accurate — exact/correct
- Adequate — sufficient
- Adverse — harmful/unfavourable
- Ambiguous — unclear
- Apparent — obvious
- Authentic — genuine
- Benevolent — kind
- Cautious — careful
- Cease — stop
- Compel — force
- Conceal — hide
- Concise — brief but complete
- Diligent — hardworking
- Diminish — reduce
- Diverse — varied
- Eager — keen
- Eliminate — remove
- Essential — necessary

F-P

- Fragile — easily broken
- Frequent — occurring often
- Genuine — real

- Hostile — unfriendly
- Humble — modest
- Inevitable — unavoidable
- Infer — deduce
- Mandatory — compulsory
- Meticulous — very careful
- Obsolete — outdated
- Obvious — clear
- Persuade — convince
- Precise — exact
- Prohibit — forbid

R-Z

- Rapid — swift
- Rare — uncommon
- Reluctant — unwilling
- Reliable — dependable
- Reveal — disclose
- Significant — important
- Sufficient — enough
- Temporary — short-term
- Vacant — empty
- Vital — essential
- Weary — tired



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13. Exam Vocabulary Strategy

Before the Exam

- Learn 15-20 useful words regularly.
- Revise old words before adding new ones.
- Maintain synonym and antonym pairs.
- Learn one sentence for difficult words.

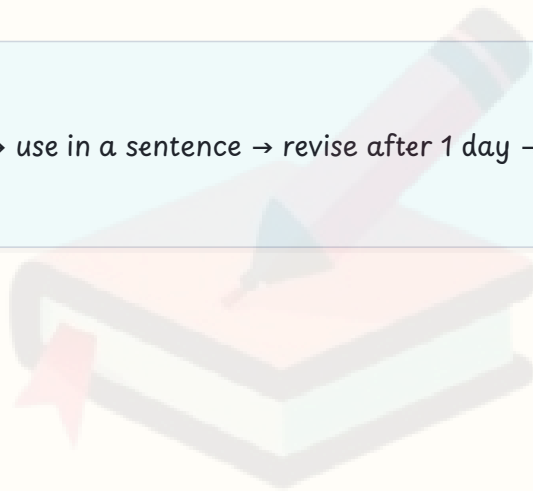
- Maintain a spelling-error list.
- Group confusing words together.

During the Exam

1. Read the complete question.
2. Identify whether it asks synonym, antonym, usage, spelling, or substitution.
3. Eliminate clearly unrelated options.
4. Use context whenever available.
5. Do not spend excessive time on one unfamiliar word.

Exam Tip

Best revision cycle: Learn → use in a sentence → revise after 1 day → revise after 1 week → test yourself.



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14. Practice Set — Vocabulary

Practice

1. Choose the synonym of **Abandon**.
A. Keep B. Leave C. Build D. Protect
2. Choose the antonym of **Ancient**.
A. Old B. Historic C. Modern D. Former
3. One who loves books is called a:
A. Bibliophile B. Misanthrope C. Polyglot D. Optimist
4. One who knows many languages is a:
A. Novice B. Polyglot C. Illiterate D. Glutton
5. One who cannot read or write is:
A. Literate B. Illiterate C. Omniscient D. Itinerant
6. "At the eleventh hour" means:
A. Very early B. At the last moment C. Every hour D. For eleven hours
7. "Break the ice" means:
A. Create a problem B. Start a friendly interaction C. End a meeting D. Break something
8. Choose the correct spelling.
A. Seperate B. Separate C. Seprate D. Separete
9. Choose the correct spelling.
A. Accomodation B. Accommodation C. Acommodation D. Accommadation
10. He gave me useful _____.
A. advices B. advice C. advise D. advises
11. Everyone came ___ Ravi.
A. accept B. advice C. except D. affect
12. Choose the antonym of **Expand**.
A. Increase B. Extend C. Contract D. Enlarge
13. Choose the synonym of **Reluctant**.
A. Unwilling B. Eager C. Certain D. Generous
14. The school ___ addressed the assembly.
A. principle B. principal C. principally D. principled
15. The car remained _____.
A. stationery B. stationary C. stationarity D. stationed

16. "Under the weather" means:

A. Outdoors B. Feeling unwell C. Travelling D. Feeling excited

17. One who loves mankind is a:

A. Misanthrope B. Philanthropist C. Misogynist D. Pessimist

18. One who cannot be conquered is:

A. Invisible B. Incurable C. Invincible D. Inaudible

19. Choose the antonym of **Permanent**.

A. Stable B. Fixed C. Temporary D. Lasting

20. Choose the synonym of **Precise**.

A. Exact B. Rough C. Vague D. Careless

21. "Spill the beans" means:

A. Waste food B. Reveal a secret C. Make a mistake D. Work hard

22. Noise can ___ concentration.

A. effect B. affect C. except D. accept

23. The ___ of the decision was significant.

A. affect B. effect C. advice D. advise

24. Choose the antonym of **Generous**.

A. Kind B. Stingy C. Helpful D. Noble

25. A life history written by oneself is called:

A. Biography B. Autobiography C. Bibliography D. Geography

26. A government by the people is:

A. Autocracy B. Oligarchy C. Democracy D. Monarchy

27. Choose the correct spelling.

A. Definately B. Definitly C. Definitely D. Definetely

28. Choose the synonym of **Obsolete**.

A. Modern B. Outdated C. Current D. New

29. Honesty is an important ___.

A. principal B. principle C. principally D. principalise

30. "Make both ends meet" means:

A. Join two objects B. Manage financially C. Finish early D. Travel widely

31. Choose the antonym of **Visible**.

A. Clear B. Obvious C. Invisible D. Apparent

32. Choose the synonym of **Diligent**.

A. Lazy B. Hardworking C. Careless D. Weak

- 33.** A person new to a profession or activity is a:
A. Veteran B. Novice C. Expert D. Master
- 34.** "Hit the nail on the head" means:
A. Work with tools B. Say exactly the right thing C. Make a mistake D. Avoid a problem
- 35.** Choose the correct spelling.
A. Pronounciation B. Pronunciation C. Pronuncation D. Pronounciaton
- 36.** Please ___ that the door is locked.
A. assure B. ensure C. insure D. assurance
- 37.** The tie ___ the shirt.
A. compliments B. complements C. complimants D. complementing
- 38.** Choose the antonym of **Hostile**.
A. Friendly B. Angry C. Violent D. Unfriendly
- 39.** "Once in a blue moon" means:
A. Very often B. Very rarely C. Every month D. At night
- 40.** Choose the synonym of **Inevitable**.
A. Avoidable B. Unavoidable C. Unlikely D. Optional
- 41.** Choose the correct spelling.
A. Enviroment B. Envirnoment C. Environment D. Environmant
- 42.** One who writes dictionaries is a:
A. Biographer B. Lexicographer C. Calligrapher D. Photographer
- 43.** Choose the antonym of **Maximum**.
A. Minimum B. Major C. Large D. Highest
- 44.** "Put off" means:
A. Wear B. Postpone C. Remove permanently D. Encourage
- 45.** The two sides reached a _____.
A. consensus B. conscious C. conscience D. consenting
- 46.** Choose the synonym of **Reveal**.
A. Conceal B. Disclose C. Hide D. Cover
- 47.** Choose the antonym of **Scarce**.
A. Rare B. Abundant C. Limited D. Insufficient
- 48.** Choose the correct spelling.
A. Occurence B. Occurrence C. Ocurrence D. Occurance
- 49.** "In the long run" means:
A. Immediately B. Eventually/over a long period C. Randomly D. Never

50. He gave me a sincere ____.

A. compliment B. complement C. complementary D. complimenting



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15. Answer Key

Q	Ans	Key Point
1	B	abandon = leave
2	C	ancient ↔ modern
3	A	bibliophile
4	B	polyglot
5	B	illiterate
6	B	last moment
7	B	start friendly interaction
8	B	separate
9	B	accommodation
10	B	advice = noun
11	C	except = excluding
12	C	expand ↔ contract
13	A	reluctant = unwilling
14	B	principal = school head
15	B	stationary = not moving
16	B	feeling unwell
17	B	philanthropist
18	C	invincible
19	C	permanent ↔ temporary
20	A	precise = exact
21	B	reveal a secret

Q	Ans	Key Point
22	B	affect = usually verb
23	B	effect = usually noun
24	B	generous ↔ stingy
25	B	autobiography
26	C	democracy
27	C	definitely
28	B	obsolete = outdated
29	B	principle = rule/belief
30	B	manage financially
31	C	visible ↔ invisible
32	B	diligent = hardworking
33	B	novice
34	B	exactly right
35	B	pronunciation
36	B	ensure = make certain
37	B	complement = completes/goes well with
38	A	hostile ↔ friendly
39	B	very rarely
40	B	inevitable = unavoidable
41	C	environment
42	B	lexicographer
43	A	maximum ↔ minimum
44	B	put off = postpone
45	A	consensus = general agreement

Q	Ans	Key Point
46	B	reveal = disclose
47	B	scarce ↔ abundant
48	B	occurrence
49	B	eventually/over time
50	A	compliment = praise

🔑 Remember

PET Vocabulary Formula:

Word → Meaning → Part of Speech → Synonym/Antonym → Usage → Confusing Pair → Revision → Practice

This is the standard to follow for the remaining PET English notes.

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